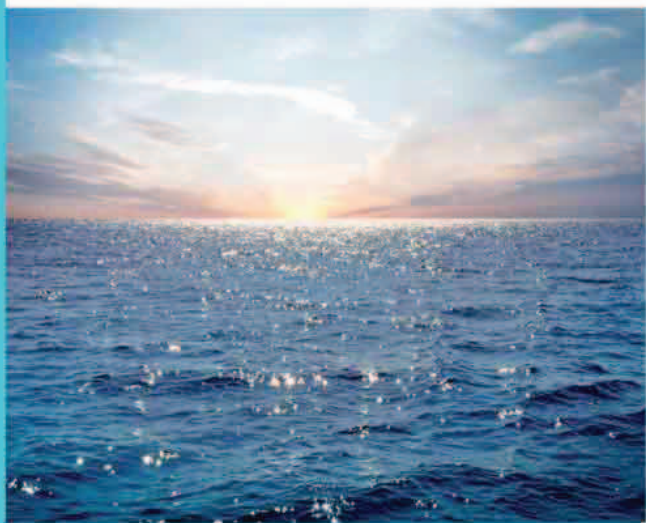


Planet ocean

Our planet should be called planet ocean, because most of its surface is covered by ocean water. It is the only planet in the solar system that is like this, and the only planet we know about that supports any form of life. This is no coincidence, because water is vital to life. The oceans were probably where life on Earth began.

BLUE PLANET

If viewed from space, you would see most of Earth's surface covered by water; less than a third of the world's surface is dry land, the rest is covered by oceans. The ocean water has a total volume of 319 million cubic miles (1.3 billion cubic km). This is more than a thousand times the volume of land above sea level. Different types of fish and other sea creatures can live anywhere within this mass of water, making it the biggest habitat on Earth.



This view of Earth shows the Pacific Ocean

If all the oceans were put together, they would make a planet two-thirds of Earth's size

If all the land was put together, it would make a planet less than a third of Earth's size

IDEAL DISTANCE

Earth is at just the right distance from the Sun to be warm enough to have oceans of liquid water. If it were nearer, it would be too hot, and the water would evaporate. If it were further away, the water would freeze solid. Our atmosphere also helps by acting like a warm blanket, keeping Earth warmer than the nearby but airless Moon.